

alliance? Everyone gains from us but we gain from none.

Q. But Rahul feels that the 1996 alliance harmed the Congress. Do you feel that the Congress has become more anti-BSP under Rahul?

A. What difference does that make? Let it be. We all saw what happened back in May 2004.

Q. Some people accuse you of practising the politics of blackmail.

A. Where is the blackmail in asking for SPG for my security? I am not asking for money for myself, for a house or a bungalow. I have only raised issues that are for the good of the people of UP. You call that blackmail? Financial aid is not blackmail. What reply will I give to the people of my state who will ask us why are we supporting the Centre that is not giving us any aid? BJP told me in 2003 that it wanted to see me as CM forever. I understood that they wanted me to remain in UP while they ruled at the Centre. They wanted me to support them in 60 out of 80 seats in the state in the event of a mid-term poll. I said

"BJP cheated me in 1997, when we shared power in UP. I got my chance a year later and cheated them."



no. They put political pressure on me and embroiled me in the Taj Corridor case. They also lodged a disproportionate assets case against me. Then BJP went out and the Congress came to power. You know income tax appellate had given me a clean chit one-and-half years ago. What has happened now is only the confirmation of the tribunal's order. Why was the clean chit being held over since 2004?

Q. In 1998, you promised Vajpayee your support and then changed your mind during the vote of confidence.

A. They cheated me in 1997, when BSP and BJP had a power-sharing arrangement in UP. They are *dhoke-*



baaz (not to be trusted) and *jhoote* (liars). When I was CM, I did not try to break their party and even gave them the post of the speaker. But six months later, they tried to break my MLAs. Just as they cheated me, I cheated them. I said in Parliament that I will abstain and then the next day voted against them (NDA government in 1998). I said



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